THE DEATH OF TABULA RASA

Hötorgsskraporna as a speculative post-work future
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Abstract

The Hötorget buildings have long been a symbol of Swedish modernist and technological faith in the future of white collar workers, offices and the cityscape.

However as the long-awaited technology arrived and progressed, we have begun to realize and be affected by the consequences on several levels: the cityscape, with its endless possibilities of aesthetic expression, has become a posthistoric bundle. The offices have lost their stability, and have gradually filtered out all personality in the name of marketing. At the same time, white-collar workers stand on the threshold of irrelevance, facing an artificial challenger.

Through a speculative future scenario of one of the Hötorget buildings, this project hopes to concretize how these changes, or crises, in society can be used as tools to help advance a better relationship with our built environment through a more radically sustainable adaptive strategy when the status quo falters.

How this thesis is read:

This text is both a historical and theoretical exploration of this specific context the context of the culturally listed five Hötorget skyscraper buildings (from here on Hötorgsskraporna) and modernisms process into the future. After an introduction the text will be strucured around the past, present, and future of the building Hötorgsskrapan number two and its surrounding theoretical context. The speculative elements of this thesis are written in: *italic and grey font in order to distinguish them as completely speculative.* In the future section the text is deliberately fragmented, for the reader to make his or her own vision possible. The thesis ends with a reflection on Hötorget buildings as a speculative post-work future and the death of tabula rasa – which can be understood as the blank slate ideals of carbon modernity.

Key words in alphabetical order: *Abstraction, AI Impact, Positive Barbarism, Post-Work, Progress, Speculation*

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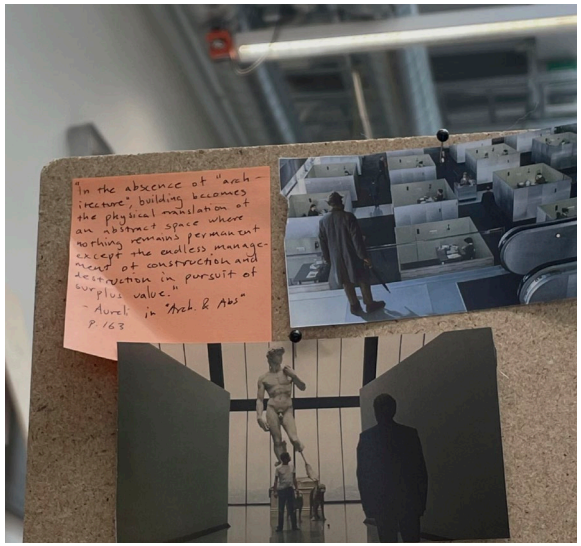
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The favorite thesis of standard and Marxist economists alike ... is that the power of technology is without limits. We will always be able not only to find a substitute for a resource which has become scarce, but also to increase the productivity of any kind of energy and material. Should we run out of some resources, we will always think up something, just as we have continuously done since the time of Pericles. Nothing, therefore, could ever stand in the way of an increasingly happier existence of the human species. One can hardly think of a more blunt form of linear thinking. By the same logic, no healthy young human should ever become afflicted with rheumatism or any other old-age ailments; nor should he ever die (Georgescu-Roegen 1975, p. 360).*

*The thinking of such a linear progression is both so attractive in my eyes – especially because of my personal connection to rheumatism – but also wishfully childish because you want to believe in a never-ending acceleration even if all odds and facts tell you otherwise, which is why what follows is both a utopian and dystopian metamorphis of our current predicament that accepts as much as it disregards reality and its evolving societal systems.



Img. 1: Photograph by author: p.o.v. of study, references of significance. Quote from Aureli (2023), screenshot from *Playtime* by Tati (1967), & screenshot from *Children of Men* by Cuarón (2006).

Introduction

This spatial design master thesis originated as a need to explore the urgent need of cultural change within architecture. Our society should prioritize above all a switch to valuing space and its material as not merely monetary and for profit but valuing them experientially and sustainably because of the cascadingly damaging consequences that the modern capitalistic system has on the overconsumption of resources through recent modernity.

Situating the narrative of our current cultural climate needs within a physical *context*, a defined socioeconomic *system*, and through a set *time period* helps guide how one can navigate the variables of this necessary cultural shift and draw explicit conclusions through spatial investigations. In this case the context is the modernist building and integrated office spaces of the *Hötorgsskrapan* (number 2 out of 5) in Stockholm, Sweden, and the system is a faltering *modernity*. This exploration situates itself as a survey of the *longue durée* development of our recent modern industrial history leading up to today, where we can identify several crises in the present, that eventually also traverses us into the future which will inevitably redefine our architectural culture, for better or for worse depending on our adaptability – which defines the time period: *the beginning of the 20th century until the end of the 21th century*.

Hötorgsskraporna are the epitome of modernist fetishized architecture and their programming the epitome of the modernist cityscape. These monstrosities properly narrate how technological advancement is abstracted* in the built environment by the principle of a techno-optimistic mindset that framed the future as a linear or even accelerationist progression in the midst of

*In *Architecture and Abstraction* Pier Vittorio Aureli (2023) redefines *abstraction* within architecture as a consequence of the development of architectural tools and division of labor that situates the impacts of external forces and societal variables in a modern society as a continual process of cause and effect, rather than what the geometrically and spatially reductionist interpretation of the word has most commonly implied.

the postwar years. Given that the buildings' were cited as the five trumpet blasts as an argument for being the crescendo of the orchestra piece that is the Stockholm urban expression, the building's hope of urban significance was high at the time of creation (Gullberg 2001).

The symmetrical and abstracted grid, which repeats upwards through more than a dozen floors within these buildings, created a tabula rasa* – blank or clean slate – infrastructure for the development of office spaces where the modern workforce can evolve over time in a fordist fashion. The image of them was at the time of creation one of wonder and never-ending technological progress – but having aged into a society that, according to Zizek (2025, p. 13) and many others, needs to rethink and redefine progress – should therefore pivot the architectural development of these structures. The current status quo – the sociopolitical state of things – is not equipped to handle non-linear progression in an environmentally sustainable fashion even if the spatiality of the Hötorgsskraporna is optimized for change, a quality that has up until now been submerged beneath the values of outdated capitalist ideals.

This situation, of a modernity that ran awry, was built on innovations of epic proportions that revolutionised the built environment and what it meant to create a modern city globally in the 20th century; from steel beams and concrete, to the elevator and curtain walls – the combination of these technologies created new possibilities beyond any previous ambitions. We now live with a cacophony of these creations with varying degrees of interpreted combinations – aesthetically, functionally, and technically – within buildings and their interiors, whether they are modern or post-modern, constructivist or de-constructivist, or any other -ism. They are often re-creations, reactions or counter-reactions to one another which according to Vidler (2008, p. 167), has created a

*Tabula rasa is a latin phrase which translates as blank or clean slate but the connotations are not only spatial but also refer to social and philosophical fields. Modernism adapted it as a justification and tool for the reengineering of society in utopian vision that ignored the consequences of having clean breaks.

"posthistoric" contemporary urban environment of undefinability. With the current understanding of a sustainable frame of mind the cacophony needs to be a continually plastic backdrop which we never again divert to. This is part of the redefined progress as we have to continually adapt to all aspects of the existing; reuse, restructure, redefine with the minimal impact across various domains as the new hierarchical factor. We need to start living with time and structures as continuously constructed and deconstructed beings.

The purpose of this thesis is to develop a narrative over time that distinctly guides how the adaptation of the existing, with its historical and contemporary implications, can navigate a sustainable practice with some of the only things we know will find us in the near and far future: crises that forces re-evaluations and should therefore be understood as possible tools. The thesis asks: *How can a future scenario of an evolved version of one of the Hötorgsskraporna express the cultural shift of a sustainable practice with the crises that modern life will present us with?*



Img. 2: Photograph by Pål-Nils Nilsson of one of the Hötorgsskrapor, 1960s.

*The Past**

*This chapter intends to situate Hötorgsskraporna within the *longue durée* of western society as they were built in the higly formative years of post war period of the late 1950s and start of 1960s by five different highly regarded swedish architects but all were overseen by david Helldén (Gullberg 2001).

Modernity is an ongoing, approximately half a millennia long, plastic process. Its nestling development was all-encompassing for mankind as it affected most, or even all, of our societal facets, even today. The plastic nature of adaptation to the economic and political -isms of its contexts is best described by Karl Marx himself: “All that is solid melts into air” (Marx & Engels 1848, p. 39).

The groundwork of a society striving towards a ruthless melting plasticity is what created the industrialized, globalized, and mass produced urban environment of recent history which sets the stage for the architecture of the modern office building. A stage for mostly democratic liberal, 9 to 5 workers, who have reached further in their labor efficiency than any generation before, these upgraded capabilities break almost all bonds of tradition between generations and alienate them from each other (Berman 1982). This upheaval that a modern plastic society has on both how and where labor is performed greatly impacts the infrastructure behind. The abstraction of such a system disorients even the architect who has gone from being the master builder during the beginnings of modernity to what could be considered a paper pusher in our current climate that is controlled more by its circumstances rather than the other way around (Aureli 2023, Introduction) – which greatly impact urban cityscape and can be dissected within a building such as one of the Hötorkssraporna.

A society that values and expects plastic changes needs spatial and social tools to be able to dynamically perform said changes. In a mostly chronological order Pier Vittorio Aureli (2023), in his book *Architecture and Abstraction*, walks us through a distinction of how the architecture develops in relation to this societal change through

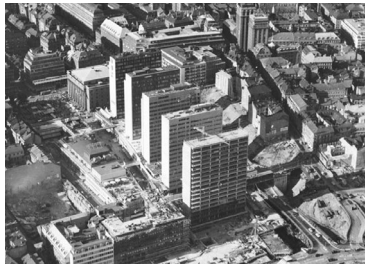
different social and political contexts; both in scale, through which tools are available and overall needs are developed. The intention was to define distinct moments of changes to the architectural role and culture through the *longue durée* of modern society and more specifically (which is of interest for this work) of the 20th century and post war time period – which was so heavily impacted by the military industrial complex. It was a time where the capital needs and technological developments dominated almost completely the project process throughout. All this resulted in the need for measurable and adaptive (read plastic) spatial and material solutions – a quantifiable process. This need was and is distributed, for both architect and builder, tools and standardisations. The logical grid's measurability was exemplified by

> The architecture of the factory, informed exclusively by productive parameters, is the most direct physical embodiment of capital's capacity to abstract everything into quantifiable data: the ground zero of what we can call 'rational architecture' (Aureli 2023, p. 146)

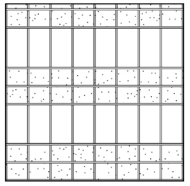
since it impacted the labor and management of the workers equally to the construction logic of the *rational architecture* – which is precisely what Hötorgsskraporna portrayed in their origin (img. 3). The process created systemization of all parties involved.

The *rational* idea is a correlating one to how Martin Reinhold (2005) describes the form and aesthetic origins of modernistic post war corporate architecture's expression that is continually impacted by the circumstances of its surrounding, where he more specifically focuses on the curtain wall and office buildings rather than the factory:

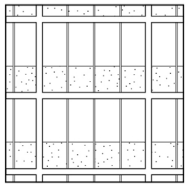
> … the architecture of the curtain wall and of patterned modularities haunts all debates in today's digital age, which is to say today's global-



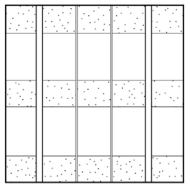
Img. 3: Aerial photo, Oscar Bladh 1962.



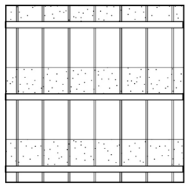
a. sheath (hidden structural elements)



b. grid (both directions structural elements directions equally emphasized)



c. mullion (vertical structural elements emphasized)



d. spandrel (horizontal structural elements emphasized)

Img. 4: Curtain wall classifications, adapted from Martin (2005, p. chapter on Physiognomy of the Office) adapted from McCallum (1957, p. 300).

> ized age, an age that began in both senses in the wartime cauldron of technological innovation and market realignment. … Along the lost highways of the postindustrial landscape, the digital age has thus found its architectural expression as a routinized amalgam of historical pastiche and technological triumphalism (ibid, p. 13).

These modular ideals and tools that aesthetically highlighted the rational architecture (see images of curtain wall logics illustrated in img. 4) is what distinguishes such buildings as distinctly modern as they were seen as a few of the 20th century tools of architectural development towards a fetishized technologically dependent future, which at the time seemed inevitable – referring specifically to the origin and time of the Hötorgsskraporna of approximately early 1960s. A time period in which high rises with these characteristics littered most urban milieus, mostly as a marketing tool for its company while arguing for its rationale aesthetics as an expression of democracy, trying hard to associate these monumental buildings with a higher ideal (Kåberg 2003, p. 336). Architects during the end of the 19th and beginnings of the 20th century saw these developments – the age of the machine that experienced accelerated industrialisation – and regarded them as transitions that would drastically change the architectural landscape of how things were conducted. According to Frank Lloyd Wright this would be a liberating force:

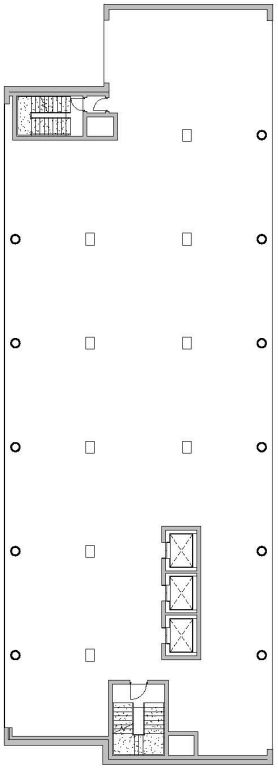
> [Through my work I have become convicted that] in the machine lies the only future of art and craft – as I believe, a glorious future; that the machine is, in fact, the meta morphosis of ancient art and craft; that we are at last face to face with the machine – the modern Sphinx – whose riddle the artist must solve if he would that art live – for his nature holds the key. (Wright 1901, p. 77)

one which creates a godlike artist as the forces of nature are wielded to their will. I would argue that this is also highlighted through Louis Sullivan's (1896) conviction when describing the high rises possible impact and programming in his text *The Tall Office Building Artistically Considerated*, in which he famously declared his mantra "form ever follows function, and this is the law" (p. 408). and continued about the utopian democratic repetitive expansion of the skies that these buildings would provide. These ideas overlap as both declare boldly how architectural works (and for Sullivan more specifically for the idealistic high rise) could develop during this time while speculating ahead where these ideals are continually enmeshed with the plastic values of modernity. Their convictions were born from some newly advanced and more readily available mass produced instruments that helped create an ever-imaginate, unnatural, and explorative built environment. A few of these significant instruments for these creations were: concrete, which paved the way for most plastic and modular creations; the elevator and "steel manufactures has shown the way to safe, rigid, economical constructions rising to a great height"(Sullivan, p. 403), which helped colonize the skies; and finally the detail of the curtain wall (img. 2 & 4), which could abstract our architecture into the fetishized ideal aesthetics of modernity in the post war period (Reinhold 2005, p. 77). In combining these tools and materials rational architecture was created in its then perceived ideal form, where the system behind its creation was highlighted first and foremost – they also constituted the major components of what makes up the Hötorgsskraporna.

One can debate what type of machine can be subjected to the understandings Wright implied but in the eyes of Le Corbusier the machine, within modernist construction, was the paradoxical liberator, a finding he unearthed with the definition of his five points of architecture and more distinctly with the exploration of the Dom-Ino concept. He understood that with these industrial tools, speed and possibilities (which heighten the *rational* architecture), would open up at the expense of the sculptural – what can be considered the artistic aspects – within architectural aesthetics and construction. Le Corbusier at first had a similar reaction to Sullivan, one of positivity, however Le Corbusier counterreacted or even almost reverted completely and therefore developed this paradoxical aspect of the machine (i.e. the industrial, mechanical and modular) within architecture. Specifically he understood this paradox in relation to how the facade was offset from the load-bearing structure, creating a separation and continuous systemisation which exponentially increased the amount of industrialized parts (and spatial solution) instead of artistic solution (Aureli 2023, p. 213-214).* This conditioning between machine and man – systemisation and craft, engineer and artist – is key in understanding the central theme: the evolution of modernity, as its plastic development is highlighted throughout the parallel history of Hötorgsskraporna. Hötorgsskraporna distinctly used all of the aforementioned architectural *strategies* (pastiche curtain wall facade of military-industrial complex), *techniques* (measurable grid vertically repeated) and *materials* (technologically dependent) that created the abstracted and rational ideal modern office building.

The plasticity that modernity exhibits through *rational* architecture can be highlighted with, for instance, the grid which is so adamant on measurability, openness and adaptability in order to maximise efficiency that it inadvertently created what I would call the infrastructure of a tabula rasa in all scales (not purely the building such as the Dom-Ino): for the town, the neighborhood, the building, the interior and so on. And for(-dist) its intended purpose it successfully did so through several modernist precedents.

Ludwig Hilberseimer's Vertical City [see img. 6], Hannes Meyer's Co-op Interior, and Marga-



Img. 5: Plan drawing of Hötorgsskrapan number 2 – showcasing its rationality.

*The architects which were referred to here were, during this historical time, mostly cast from the same mold. However this is mostly just a consequence of the racially biased patriarchy that gave them the platform to influence and make the most noise.

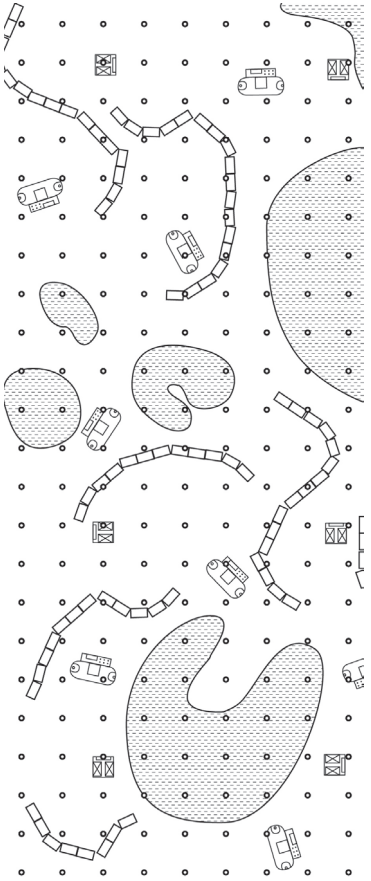


Img. 6: Interpretation by author of Ludwig Hilberseimer's Vertical City, 1924.

> rete Schütte-Lihotsky's kitchens revealed that the logic of mass production was no longer confined to the factory but had in fact penetrated every aspect of human life, thus mobilizing the entire spectrum of social relationships. (Aureli 2023, p. 235)

This *mass production* of Platonic objects, that together made up the modern spatialities throughout all scales, conditions modern civilization as a highly abstracted and rational one. Their assembly, from the bird's eye-view, tinkers on the nerve of capitalist realism (Fisher 2014a) as its medium distinctly, if interrogated, speaks repeatedly of the mechanical need that the capitalist structure demands. The so-called penetrating mobilization that Aureli distinguishes is the symbiotic relationship between the people and their societal system – which in this case is a capitalist modernist one – cannot stop as its spread and changes both parties continually in relation to each other. The system of mechanized society affected the inhabitants of it as much as the inhabitants craved and created its structure, it's a dependency loop. The Archizoom provocation project called *No-Stop City* (Img. 7) was meant to emulate the pinnacle of this capitalist rational system as it completely surrenders to its outer affective capitalist rational variables. Creating a highly developed infinite and therefore ubiquitous infrastructure of spatial tabula rasa where architecture disappears – the great attractive fear Le Corbusier felt – because of the infinite rational infrastructure that replaced architectural buildings as the site of action and programmes.

If one wants to distinguish the enclosure of capitalist realism on a global scale this provocation project of continual repetition (which is what I would argue that Archizoom were doing) seems unnecessary from the point of view of Keller Easterling in her book on *Extrastatecraft* (2014, p. 13), since one does not have to create architectural fictions of this distinctly architectural infrastructure since it can be found in the modern globalized and mass produced world order, from architectural buildings, digital networks, to credit cards – their reproducibility narrates the power of infrastructure space. This space needs several levels of interrogation beyond the spatial dimension that Archizoom mainly resides within. The cybernetic and overall digitised mediums Easterling (2014) defines – which expands infrastructure beyond the normal spatially logistic conventions – provides an expanded idea about the infrastructure of tabula rasa where the ideals of plastic modernity are dependent on much of the same concepts of globalised, rational, mass production for a standardised system but across more spectrums of society such as both digital and physical products. The feeling of integration and nested interest of such a symbiotic relationship that plastic modernity expects of its subjects is therefore expanded into all aspects and scales of our intended infrastructure (Easterling 2014, p. 14). This expands the capitalist realism ideology while also putting new light into the expansion of how integrated the plastic modernity is within most aspects of a building, its parts and its extended factions. Hötorgsskraporna – which aptly applied itself to these ideals through its adaptations of modernity – has and continues to go through and express this plastic nature of modernity. But at what cost is the *tabula rasa* infrastructure of these buildings firstly created (see img. 8 & 9) and then maintained (see *The Present* chapter)?



Img. 7: Interpretation by author of No-Stop City from Archizoom in 1969.

Conclusion of The Past

Our metamorphing with the mechanics and the aforementioned Sphinx, that Sullivan (1896) explained, promised a nirvana that is an elevated playing field within architecture that would create the ideal modern urban environment. This process is however a double-edged sword which we have digested previously in how it nestles itself into each genre of architectural needs: function, form, scales, products, aesthetics, programming, labor processes, networks etc. Creating the modern man from the insatiable need for plastic changes infects all of these aspects with a significantly affective disease.

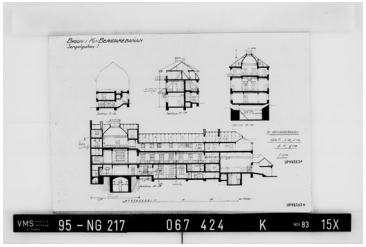
> Now this is a familiar twentieth-century refrain, shared by those who love the modern world and those who hate it: modernity is constituted by its machines, of which modern men and women are merely mechanical reproductions. (Berman 1982, p. 29)*

The cultural and architectural aspects of modernity that emphasise on technological and machine developments needs this contextual interrogation because of its ability to symbiotically "shape modern men and women" (ibid, p. 29). As this progresses over time the values, and in turn the omniscale infrastructure, expects this evolving plastic nature of all parties involved. This demand supplies the ideology of the time.

The Hötorgsskraporna when created was meant to be perceived as an automatic monument* for modernity with its climate and gravity bending powers that stretched the natural forces into a homogenous space that concurred all through its technological achievement. Its white collar post fordist ideals of the urban image survived and successfully created the office space and interiors of post war modernity. It has continually utilized the innate tabula rasa infrastructural spatiality to express different versions of that same ideology until today.

*The pages referred to changes depending on whether it is the English or Swedish version. If the quotes are English then that page originate from the original English version even if the Swedish translation is the version of which the book was read in.

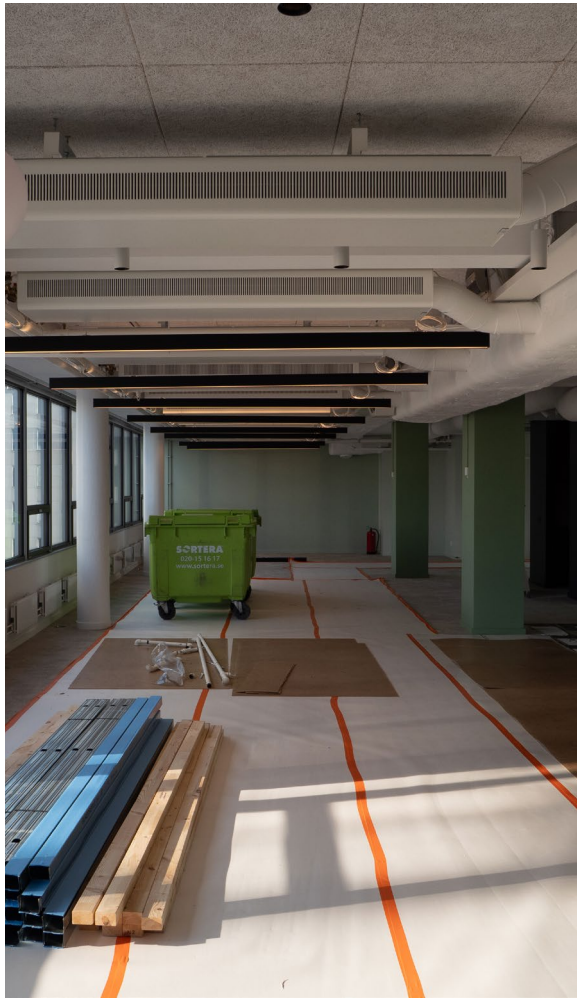
*Referring to the fictional idea of skyscrapers by Rem Koolhass in his (1978, p. 104) Delirious New York: A retroactive manifesto for Manhattan.



Img. 8: Drawings of the buildings which previously stood were Hötorgsskraporna now stand. Courtesy of Riksantikvarieämbetet.



Img. 9: Photograph by Pål-Nils Nilsson of the spatial implications of a tabula rasa modernity. Hötorgsskraporna in the background, 1960s.



Img. 10: Photograph by the author of the maintenance that is demanded within a building such as Hötorgsskrapan 2. Level 6, March 2026.

*The Present**

*This chapter inteands to situate Hötorgsskraporna within the paradoxes of contemporary western society of Stockholm in 2026. The property owner and developer, which is a national pension fund Vasakronan own and operate it as a trendy office building that follows the trends of the present for the needs of its tenants with the tools that the past left us with.

Today modernity feels ironically enough rather old-fashioned and oblivious. The need of societal redefinition and technological optimism that defined early modernism was thought to be completely passé by the post-structural philosophers (such as Foucault, Baudrillard & Derrida) that defined the subsequent postmodern discourse, which largely began in the aftermath of the 1968 events in France (Berman 1982). However I agree with Berman who argues against this because of the plastic nature that modernism holds, which allows it to have both "perpetual self-critique and self-renewal. (1982, p. 15)" characteristics and therefore adapted accordingly. These philosophical distinctions are not applicable in a direct sense (even *modernism* as a concept should not be used as such a big umbrella term which it has here) to the spatial design exploration of Hötorgsskraporna, but these excursions are significant in defining the evolution of the cultural progression of the status quo which is the driving force of how the buildings: were created, are maintained, and how they could end up. We, as a contemporary western society, are (through infrastructures such as Hötorgsskraporna) exploring societal redefinitions of modernity that face conflicting interests – such as political neoliberalism with environmental sustainability – whilst still heavily dependant on technological developments and the system that (carbon) modernity created.

We then return to the aforementioned Marx and Engels quote, extended this time: "All that is solid melts into air, all that is holy is profaned, and man is at last compelled to face, with sober senses, his real conditions of life, and his relations with his kind" (Marx & Engels 1848, p. 39). In our current metamorphosing modernity, Hötorgsskraporna is a catalyst. The building and its



Img. 11: Perspective of 3d point cloud of the two floors 5 & 6 from Hötorgsskrapan number 2. Under construction for implementation of a central staircase between the floors for an office that needs both floors."

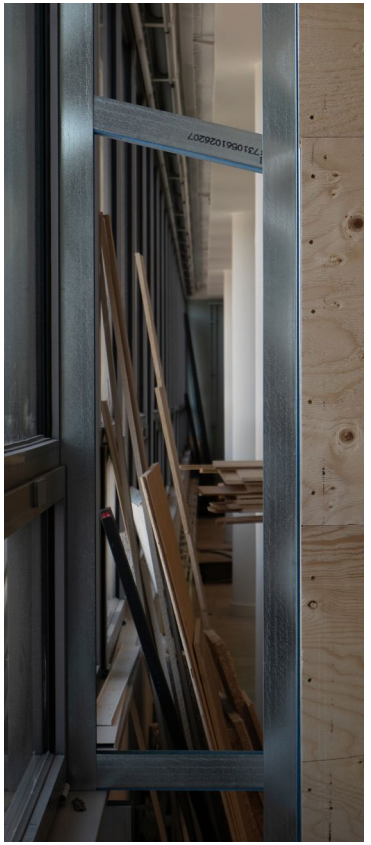
intrinsics values, parts, programmes, can help us speculate, with the aforementioned *sober senses,* the future artificial and postcarbon modernity we are, or should be, heading towards. The *melted solid* of the office buildings parts and its subjects, along with the *holy* that is *profaned*: the technological and societal progression of modernity which was misguided and misunderstood as linear, help situate how we navigate the historical rituals and contemporary crises we have inherited, as we move towards a post work society.

The *holy* of modernity is considered its progress. However, with technological advancements there comes possibilities to *soberly sense* its consequences, such as the CO2 emissions impact of global climate change. This is where the dialectical discourse around modernity's progress starts to clash. In his book of essays *Against Progress*, Slavoj Zizek (2025) borrows Hegelian ideas and wants us to continually redefine progress: "progress is never a linear approximation to some pre-existing goal since every step forwards that deserves the name 'progress' implies a radical redefinition of the very notion of progress" (Zizek 2025, p. 14) and also to more contemporarily, paraphrasing his fellow Japanese philosopher Kohei Saito, regarding our climate change ordeals: "the only way to achieve real progress today is to problematize the very notion of progress which dominates not only our ideolo-

gy but our actual lives" (ibid, p. 14). This implies that nothing is really distinctly good enough if we are to behave progressively. Danish architect Søren Philmann in his book *Making Matter What Too Often Does Not Matter* contemporary take on superlocal sustainability helps paint a picture of such a redefining of material progress within modernity and its tabula rasa ideals:

> Concrete made a place for placeless modernity. Like Baudrillardian simulacrum, an image built upon images, concrete makes an image of rock where there is no rock. It makes something appear from nothing by disguising its origins. In this way, it enacts a fantasy of architecture: the dream of alchemy; invention ex nihilio. A building whose materials define and impose a place rather than emerge from it. (2025, p. 26)

Following this paragraph Philmann (along with poet Adam Dickinson) goes on to distinguish how the need for a metabolic interrogation of the existing material instead of the creation of architectural *placeless modernity*, which concrete provides, is the necessary sustainable progression. Imagine the progression as this: sourced local rocks created architectural stability – progression is redefined – concrete helped create the ideal mass produced rock – progression is redefined again – sourced local concrete continues architectural and planetary stability. Simplified as this previous sentence is, it can be interpreted as pure redefinitions of progress, which would make it stop at the historical Hegelian idea, without using the next contemporary step from Saito of problemitization of the progression. For example, what happens at the end of the pile of materials that can be metabolized? In this there needs to be further redefinition of progress beyond the scale of its materiality and use. It needs to reach further into the status quo on a global and political sphere, much like the reach that Jane Hutton achieves in her *Reciprocal Landscapes: Stories of*



Img. 12: Photograph by author of Hötorgsskrapan 2 during renovation, Level 6 April 2026.

material landscapes in which – I would argue – she defines similar redefinitions of material lifespans, much like the reused and sourced concrete, as both; a better technique of appreciation and resourcefulness, and yet also a fetishization of the commodity since the process disregards the origins of production of the concrete, the lifespan, and progression the material goes through which often creates an ecological unequal exchange between its site of production and consumption (Hutton 2019, p. 6).
This advanced processing of architectural progress presents an impossible task which would require nothing short of a buddhist nirvanian long term temporal perspective of material and immaterial appreciation for all aspects of the built and lived environment. But, that is the kind of problematization of progress that is needed in order to reach what has been defined as the new progressive state: sustainable and critical rather than blindly techno-optimistic.

A progress that is continually, self-critical, problematized and redefined is also continually haunted. The concept of *hauntology,* first introduced by Derrida (1994) emphasized the impact of spectres of failures,

> [Hauntology] ... referred to the way in which nothing enjoys a purely positive existence. Everything that exists is possible only on the basis of a whole series of absences, which precede and surround it, allowing it to possess such consistency and intelligibility that it does. (p. 38)

Specific to this concept was how it relates over time. According to Hägglund (2008) it can be haunted by the *not yet*, that is the future, or the *no longer*, that is the past, spectres. In this case the past spectre is the rational, plastic, and techno-optimistic carbon modernity that is physically stuck with us through the spatiality that Hötorgsskraporna represent which is filled with mainly material traces of a haunting past, and immaterial traces of a haunting future.

The past haunts us with what we historically heavily relied upon, a linear progression that is no longer definitive. Progress now lies in interrogating existing social structures; such as labor in the urban city or the comfortably homogenous indoor environmental conditions we have come to expect as a human right in western society, dubbed *Comfortocene* by Daniel A. Barber in his essay *After Comfort*. According to Barber we have to, from a human perspective, revert and in some cases build for dis-comfort – using it as a movement to emphasize and ensure the redefinition of progress on a global scale, sacrificing for the bigger picture arguing for how the impacts of discomfort are inevitable because of the escalating climate changes. Using the omnipresent HVAC system (mechanical catalyst for modernism and curtain wall buildings such as Hötorgsskraporna) as a representative for the argument in how status quo seems unbreakable but not indefinite. He intends to make it distinctly tangible how we should conform to the nestling of carbon modernity that is consuming our future prospects of comfort as a visualizing and practical tool for understanding the future hauntings that are coming. This is a response to what Elisa Iturbe presents us with in the opening essay – *Architecture And the Death of Carbon Modernity* – in the same magazine, where she confronts the nestling plasticity of carbon modernity.

> If we seem at risk of equalizing all modern and contemporary architecture under the rubric of carbon form, negating the possibility of agency or difference, this is precisely the point. In the totalizing framework of carbon modernity, architectural thought is constantly subsumed by the ideology of the fossil economy, making it impossible to decouple both the discipline and the practice of architecture from environmental collapse. Carbon form is everywhere, and the possibility of a critical architecture is negated by its breadth. As such, it is both necessary and urgent to recognize the extent to which carbon modernity has shaped how architecture is both thought and built. (Iturbe 2019, p.19)



Img. 13: Photograph by author of Hötorgsskrapan 2 during renovation, Level 5 April 2026.

*Emphasis original from source.

This interrogation of the past spectre and in how it scares the present into carbon conformity by using the tools built by carbon modernity, such as quantification and techno-fetishization, through energy, power, and form to explore the escalating climate crisis can explain how the present seems unable to break from the belief of linear progress. Iturbe explains how the binding of the current system with modern ideals in combination with how – showcased by modernities failures – the option of a different kind of sustainable tabula rasa is no longer optional, because the blank slate does not exist beyond the mythical fable of early modernist ideology. She accurately problematizes carbon modernity's progress in a temporal sense through historical *no longer's* "The grip of yesteryear on today intensifies – or, put differently, the *causal power of the past inexorably rises* … The significance of that terrible destiny, so often warned of in climate change discourse, is the final *falling in of history on the present*" (Malm 2016, p.9)*. Wanting not to turn your back but looking ahead with blinding confidence to the future. This is the organ that needs to die for the body of carbon modernity to be buried in the carbon form it has shaped.

The uncertainty of the future, for us in the present, is mainly because of two spectres: the consequences of the aforementioned needed sustainable progress to divert from carbon modernity – which goes against most modern standards that are still nested amongst us – and what the technooptimists of past modernism (whose philosophical offspring occupy Silicon Valley) would most likely have dubbed the next coming of god, Artificial General Intelligence.

> The possibilities and pitfalls of technological and scientific advancement have been the stuff

> of centuries' worth of dreaming about human progress, yet here too we find ourselves treading a viciously circular path. Free development, experimentation and research leads to Artificial Intelligence, which not only threatens to supplant the human mind but is intended specifically to overcome its limitations, to replicate humanity without its frailties. Leaving aside more abstract questions about what this would look like and mean should it be achieved, one does not have to look very far for the dead birds [a reference to Christopher Nolan's film The Prestige in which a bird has to be squished and killed for a magic trick to work] littering the path to 'progress' like autumn leaves, from the astronomical energy costs burdening a burning planet to the people whose jobs will increasingly be done by AI. This is what blind commitment to an uncritically adopted idea of 'progress' looks like; proponents of AI talk about the freedom it brings, but are vague on freedom from what, for who and what for. Freedom for humanity to dedicate itself to leisure, art or meditation? Or freedom for an oligarchy of technocrats from the slightest tethering to the social contract, in exchange for reducing humanity to a cog in the endless self-reproduction of AI (Zizek 2025, pp. 5)?

Linear progress of modernity becomes a philosophical trap, readily available because we want to ignore those failures and hauntings. The dead birds (see the above quote) haunt us enough to act habitually in order to justify our existence: man is less and less prioritized as the protagonist with the climate and artificial agents as two new competing cast members. And herein lies the crux of our present, we are stuck with a past and a future, both looking at each other with longing eyes, wanting desperately to ignore the *not yet* or the *no longer*.

Conclusion of The Present

Returning to the building that is Hötorgsskrapan 2 we then position ourselves within this physical structure that is built upon this aged idea of a spatial tabula rasa who blindly believes it can foster a linear progress through its technological development. Throughout the building's lifespan it has seen countless tenants move in and out. The continual changing of interiors dependent on trends and tenants is effective because of the structural grid system, but relating it to the overall status quo of the system it operates within is not nearly redefined or problematized enough. I visited the buildings and saw how the needs of the tenants clashed first hand with the paradoxes of carbon modernity (img 11. & 12.). I want to quote Aureli again here: "In the absence of 'architecture', building becomes the physical translation of an abstract space where nothing remains permanent except the endless management of construction and destruction in pursuit of surplus value" (Aureli, 2023, p. 163.). From my conversations with Vasakronans building manager who granted me access I think this summarises their perspective as well, the building is not maintained for the sake of maintenance only. The spaces have to quickly adapt to the trends of office spaces and extensive needs of the tenants (Gustafsson 2026). When captured as a whole, and part of the work and life of the building, some decisions seem absurdly unnecessary and others just part of the lifecycle.*

One recent update of this particular building was the recent facade renovations that helped make the buildings better energy efficient, although not up to contemporary sustainable standards because of how they have to keep their ineffective curtain wall exterior expression, seeing as the buildings are listed as culturally significant.

Stewart Brand and Frank Duffy's so called shearing layers of a building showcases the development over time of a building. All of these changes and needs of care for the layers over time are important for anyone taking care of a building (Brand

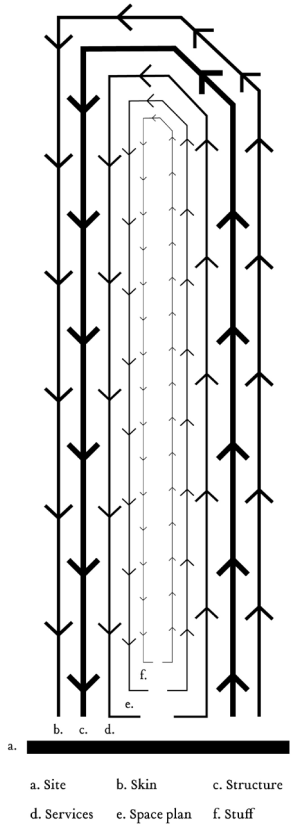
*Vasakronan focuses on making the building a "modern office product with great flexibility in the spatial design" and "want to be perceived as attractive". Since the recent covid pandemic they have a bit of trouble keeping long term tenants but keep updating, renovating, and maintaining the building as usual and at an even quicker pace because of the shifting culture post pandemic (Gustafsson 2026).

1997, see img. 13). The outer-most layers such as the skin, structure, and services still have to keep regularly scheduled programming of maintenance. However, the inner-most layers: the stuff and space plan should not be adapted and changed nearly as much or at the same pace as our contemporary status quo. In Hötorgsskrapa's case the shedding of the inner shearing layers needs to lessen as much as possible.

It goes far beyond comfort or discomfort of the indoor environment, it reaches the purely aesthetic upkeep of the building. It is as if the buildings are still haunted by the essence of modernity, the tabula rasa aesthetics of technological triumphalism having to keep a straight face through botox injections of trendy interiors of carpets and new sleek HVAC systems. As a property developer the extensive accelerating pace of renovation seems necessary but it is not problematized or redefined nearly as actively as needed. It continues to use the aforementioned tools of carbon modernity, such as quantification*, that Iturbe (2019) warned us about, which makes it far easier to disavow the responsibility of the larger systematic issues. These tools continue the past systems with the mask of a contemporary adaptation as an issue to climate change. The response does not rest solely in the lap of Vasakronan because of the rules and regulations that exists in the standardized swedish system but I get the feeling that is more of a comfort than something that actually hinders the development of the buildings into an actually sustainable response, in regards to the facade and interior maintenance. The response to the haunts of the *not yet* are also ignored (in that they get neither problematized) and only responded to with the historical tools of modernity, the blind belief that the tabula rasa infrastructure will be an adequate response to the changing work environment and the looming artificial competitor.

But then how do you respond to these predicaments? Walter Benjamin who defined the modern industrial status quo as the embodiment of

*During a visit I was made aware about the exact amount of reused aluminum of the facade into public benches but could not get a straight over why the building was constantly being torn apart and rebuilt.



Img. 14: Interpretation by author of one of Hötorgsskraporna as the shearing layers diagram from Brand (1994).

*The feeling of fear is promoted above all within this haunting contemporary culture and according to Byung Chul-Han in his nominal work *The Spirit of Hope* (2024) in which he argues that the antidote in order to break from the habits of techno-optimistic modernity is hope. Hope he argues is far more than being optimistic, it fosters criticality, agency, and action, instead of the crippling impact optimism can have as it pushes the responsibility on towards others – or as in modernity's case technology and the machine.

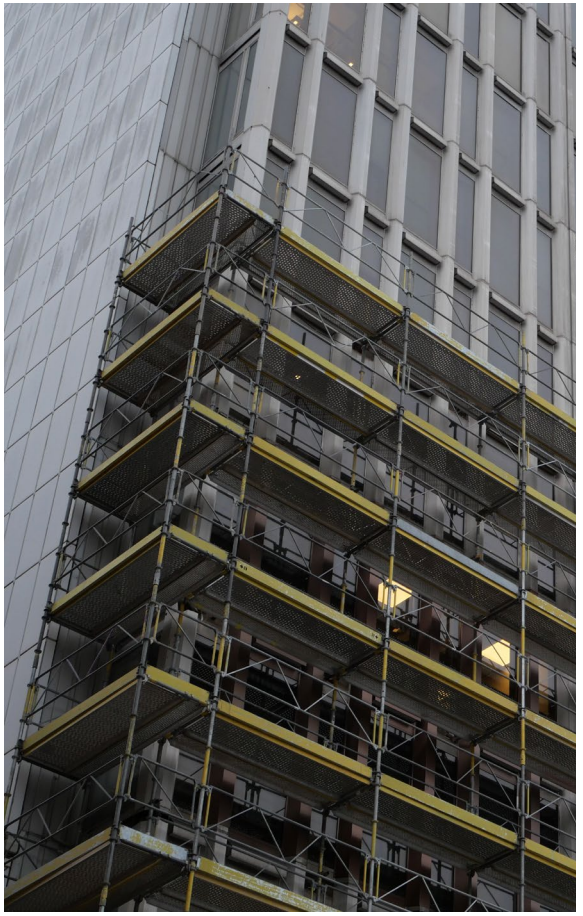
"poverty of experience": "With this tremendous development of technology, a completely new poverty has descended on mankind" (Benjamin 1933, p. 12) and according to Aureli (2023, p. 210) has this poverty reached beyond the isms of temporal factions that modernity has walked through, making it even more important to understand Benjamin's response to situation. He intends us to use the innate ability we seem to be using at present of ignorance, looking past nostalgic traditions and historical precedent: enacting the role of the barbarian but with a twisted ideology:

> Benjamin appropriated this negative definition and transformed it into a 'positive concept': the barbarian as the only genuine way of being within the predicament of the modern industrial world. For the modern barbarians, 'poverty of experience' as an invitation to start from an existential tabula rasa 'to make a little go a long way; to begin with little and build up further, looking neither left nor right. (Aureli 2023, p. 208)

The barbarian is someone who lived and continues to live through the *longue dureé* of our industrial civilization but uses not the spatial or industrial tabula rasa but the existential in order to situate and interrogate, understanding the plastic nature of each situation they are placed within, accepts their circumstances, is traditionless and practically tuned. The positive barbarian was born out of a counterreaction to all of these changes of the plastic modern society in order to handle the situation with a level-headed and hopeful (instead of blindly optimistic*) mindset that doesn't overlook what is lost but what is gained with the possibilities. The barbarian can help us with positioning in relation to how we work the two contradicting points of a modernist built environment that needs to adapt to a more sustainable frame of mind through the upcoming crises and changes our modern world will

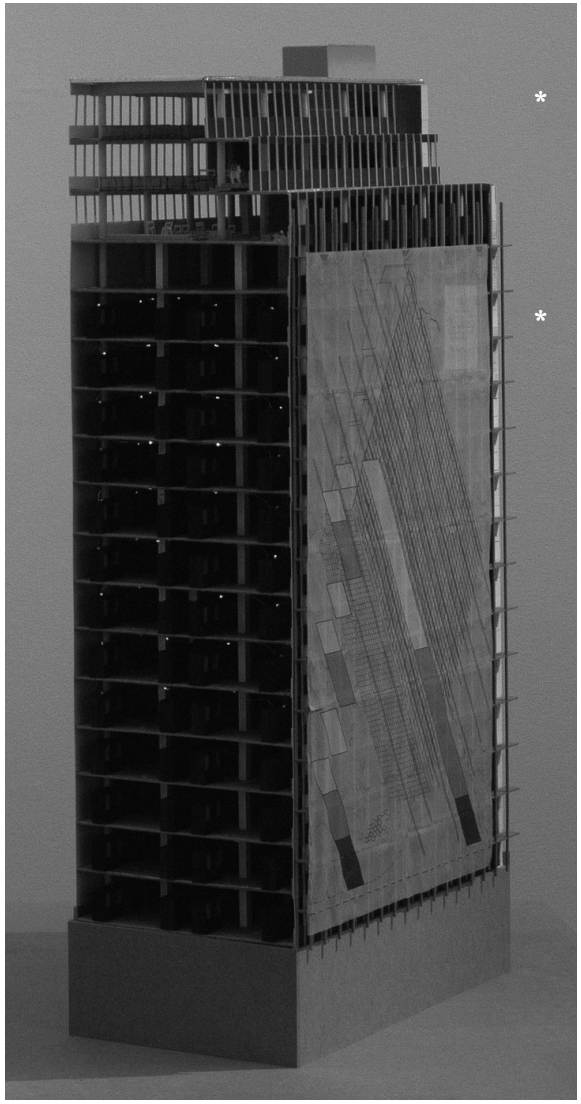
face. The barbarian might for example look at this curtain wall building as a set of parts that is nothing more than that, a set of parts that needs tuning and optimisation, much like a computer with its case. But they can ignore certain habits of the system that has binded the buildings to the carbon modernity that birthed it.

So leading us into the uncertainty of the future: firstly, modernism has built a very plastic system as it has been able to create a so-called tabula rasa infrastructure that fosters adaptability to modern development. Within the capitalist carbon based system this has fostered an renovating and exchangeable system that has great use of this infrastructure. Secondly however, the system is being abused and the contemporary sustainable frame of mind, if taken seriously, in which each material needs to be cherished, needs this excessive renovating and changing of – in this case the inner shearing layers – to lessen as much as possible. Which is where the *problematizing* and *redefining* of progress and its variables within a set system that the existential tabula rasa perspective of the *positive barbarian* can bring actual and prosperous change.



Img. 15: Photograph by author of Hötorgsskrapan 5 right before start of renovating the facade, januari 2026.*

*What is the true tabula rasa infrastructure of modernity when all that is left is maintenance?



*Last three levels are left for the use of a third space debate hall for humans.

*The 15 replicating levels below are fitted with server halls for the increasing computing demand of AI which represent the new modern office worker.

Img 16. Model in 1:50 showcasing the possible future of Hötorgsskrapan 2, 2075. Photograph by author.

*The Future**

*One of many futures but this one is dependant on how I interpret how we will navigate the development of the status quo in relationship to the crises that we are presented with at present.

Prologue

What follows are fictional writing(s) that explore the future of the Hötorget buildings in the year 2075. They are heavily based on historical and contemporary research of the buildings situated, spatial, cultural and political context. The design process and design lies within this writing as they are the larger driving forces behind. Me as the creator of these new spaces is meant to be partly objective as I let the story of past to future – which can be read as the design – write itself as it navigates the parameters it has been given through a positive barbarian narrative of interrogation.

The speculative elements of this are written in: *italic and grey font in order to distinguish them as completely speculative. As exemplified below:*

In modern times, before the Implimentation, most parties where mingling was considered the main course, one phrase dominated the initial interactions, "So... what do you do?". In a linguistic or ahistoric sense this sounds quite freeing and philosophically artistic, one person wondering what activities define and occupy another's day. But the "do" in what one is doing in this context were almost always your profession. Even being unemployed is a better answer than explaining what kind of interests could be the most dominant in your headspace. However today (2075) humans no longer can rely on that being a sufficient enough answer.

Introduction

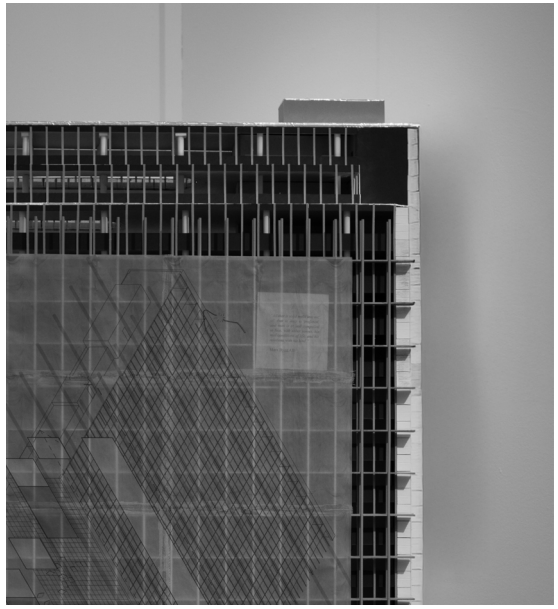
The day has just begun for humanity, sleepless nights caused by the anxiety-driven formal quarterly earnings presentations or deadlines have been rendered obsolete, most are well rested, others restless. With the accelerated pace of the AI worker mankind could do nothing but slow down and make way for its superior. Work, as the defining part of people's personality, is a story of old but for a few who consider it a crucial hobby or an escape.

The technological revolution brought forward by artificial general intelligence destabilised the job market, or even the concept of both "job" and "market". The species of man that has controlled the top spot on the food chain in such a dominant fashion for millennia through intelligence and cooperative advantages lost its vision and overstayed its visit in its newly developed globalized and interconnected arena. In this modern competition, where the species of man separated into factions of individuals, the search for tools that could provide a competitive edge resulted in humanity eagerly handing the keys to the kingdom to a monster of our own creation.

It could more aptly be expressed as an arms race of thinking machinery. The AGI revolution was a remarkable display of greed dressed in firstly ethical technological evolution – displayed as a darwinian escalation of modern civilisation – but then finally showing its true colors as the technofeudal megalomaniacal pissing contest it was. The uprising revolution – similar to the French Revolution or European two year period following 1848 – which most would have expected, never came to be. The neoliberal and entrepreneurial movement that created a globe of individuals, not a global movement. Feelings never really blossomed, voices were never raised and the agreement between what could be considered the left and right; liberal and conservative; capitalist and communist, never came to be as they were all too distracted scrambling for a long lost idea of the past continuing forever.

There were signs of this trend in most aspects of society. The flow of the aesthetics of the cityscape that helped define eras between each other slowly waned, we reached the end. Culture in the beginning of this century overall was the starting point for this circular process of referral, no new music, film, or trend were ever its own thing but a reference to time that was singular. I blame the internet but others would disagree, which is nice, because we all know the more realistic culprit, the big C who must not be named. We have learnt to accept what is, and that it continues to be until the point where it can no longer take the stretches and suspensions. We have become the observers.*

*Furthering Marx's ideas of civilisation and the development of the forces and relations of production, Byung Chul-Han in Psychopolitics (2017), means that the exact contradictions that spark social upheaval – which was thought to bring the proletariat to take control from the bourgeoisie – will no longer bring communist social order because of the parasitic infection neoliberalism has produced in the digital age. The proletariat have become optimising entrepreneurs incapable of true freedom as freedom has been colonized by self-generating capital. Which in turn makes no feasible difference between the two classes, hence no ability for upheaval against the authoritarian control of Capital (aforementioned as "the big C"). Which is why no such uprising would happen.



Img. 17: The building is under renovation as shown in the model on the western side which is getting a new facade behind the scaffolding. Photograph by author.

Algorithmic Cityscape

Growing up we learnt that the algorithm is an allknowing wonderful tool, you were meant to use it to your advantage as it always catered to you. Weave it into your work, consumption, play and everything in between in order to create the optimised and maximised life flow, it was meant to be more reliable and quicker than people around you the only way to outperform and become the all important king on the hill. This metamorphosis of a digital logistics lifestyle that significantly outweighs independent thought and interpersonal connection with physical consequences created what felt like genuine agency while it mostly created a distorted schizophrenia of unknowing dependence. This outsourcing of critical thinking in small decision making had a snowball, ripple, domino effect or viciously all of the above as it undermined an idea of being able to live without this algorithm as a permanent creature as a part of you which continually diminished the value of human experimentation and exploration.*

*The consequences weren't meant to be so overwhelming but they definitely created a new urban image of diminishing physical advertisement as the most significant cultural shift. The death of advertisement started in the digital sphere as agentic AI could both shop and know what to shop for your midsummer eve celebration while understanding that the need for a nice new shirt is equally as important as fluid replacement for the day after. These were direct actions that you asked for when in need of help to run errands but it started evolving further as the need to orient and physically be guided or take part in faded away a lot of the need for human agency, we became codependent. Which meant we as humans are no longer the ones need to be advertised to – that is our AI agents which consume only digital 1s and 0s, not visual imagery.**

*The band King Crimson's (1969) rock album opening track named *21st Century Schizoid Man* which is a social commentary on the feeling of apathy and of being in a fantasy world – which people with Schizophrenia disorder experience – created by the status quo of the modern world and the people in control. It is also heavily critical of the then ongoing Vietnam war.

*In the film *They Live* by John Carpenter from 1988 the premise is comical as aliens are portrayed as the creators and feudal class of a hegemonious capitalism. But through the literal lens of a pair of sunglasses the protagonist distinguishes the actual messaging of different mediums of information such as books and advertisement, realizing what messaging that is meant to be communicated (along with who are aliens). Our agentic present (or future depending on perspective this part should be in) could be understood as these glasses, we have no need for these communications and expressions since we are no longer the intended audience.



Img . 18: Southern facade of Hötorgsskrapan 2, 2075. Photograph by author.

Some counterreaction artistic expressions in this barren urban landscape are created in the absence of physical advertisement. The only design decisions that are made are during the maintenance of the existing at this point, when the shearing of layers is needed. In this case the facade panels are systematically exchanged to create pixelated outlines of two debating people at the height of the debate hall on the southern facade. Letting the wear and tear do the talking.

The Age of Outsourced Elightenment

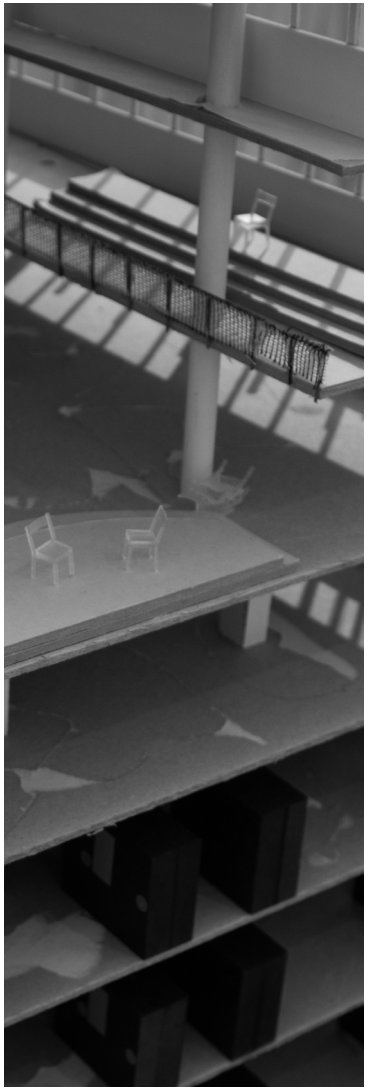
*We might have it all accessible, all connected to what feels like an invisible cloud; historical and everupdating information, reasoning, facts, argumentation, conclusions in a cacophony of information gathering into a database built on 1s and 0s that one can outsource its thinking to. The consequences of this outsourcing were initially slight and barely noticeable in the day to day but the loss of critically became escalatingly apparent as humanity became increasingly dependent on external help as their ability to value complex thoughts, weigh options or even store or trust vital information in their own heads faded.**

With original and thought-provoking answers disappearing as the Large Language Models merged more and more towards a homogenous thought engine the more information they gathered, humans lost their edge along with their confidence. The homogenous information and thought bank dissolved most human personality; starting to emerge as a necessity to combat this the new modern society gathered a small new consciousness out of something that might surprise along with the need for critical thinking. The suffocating boredom of each thought and action being outsourced to these algorithmic beings awoke a need. A need for a tool that enriches experience beyond what is expected.

**"In place of the old local and national seclusion and self-sufficiency, we have intercourse in every direction, universal inter-dependence of nations. And as in material, so also in intellectual production." (Marx & Engels 1848, p. 39) The overarching network that is created by the globalized world order extends beyond the material world and into the intellectual one, which Marx and Engels defined already in the 19th century. This network is still a spatially, albeit homogenous, distributed intellectual production where human intellectuals throughout can share and explore similar ideas through their own perspective. This process is neutralised and completely flattened if artificial intelligence becomes the major producer of intelligence. Its singularity and oligarchal producer of information and intelligence would push us beyond the nightmares of Marx and Engels. An AGI (Artificial General Intelligence) would become both the proletariat and the bourgeoisie, leaving humanity as the purely consumers rather than producers.



Img. 19: Easter facade which has new facade for levels with server halls. Photograph by author.



Img. 20: Section where stage is situated above the server halls. Photograph by author.

My implementation is not the best one or the most practical one, but it balances the realities of the crises to create some sort of assembly between now and then. The intended idea is that repetative levels should house server halls, letting in the new guard of artifical white collar workers. This is a development that recognises that such a programme might be the best and only profitable tenant in this building in the future if we were to adopt a barbaric perspective. They are the new workers and they do not have the need for new interiors or space plan changes – or even sunlight* – just their own shell of server racks, a strict spatial structur, and energy. This limits the interiority change excess and I would argue it metaphorically would embody the next step of the modernist industrial evolution as it's a continuation of the building's structural system to a smaller scale and humans could only ever really dream of being such efficient tenants.

* Looking at it from a distance the eastern facade feels as if it looks back mockingly, the pattern that so sharlpy created a technofetishtic pastiche of the past continues as reminder.

*Fictional debate**
(Read with caution, completely promted)

ELAN

The deepest barbarism is ecological. Western society placed production above ecology, capital above commons, quarterly return above geological time. That is the return to barbarism — not torches in the street, but the slow foreclosure of the conditions under which human society is possible at all.

MIRA

We must be precise. It is not that humanity forgot to prioritise the planet. We invented pristine nature at the very moment we were industrially eviscerating it. What we gave up was the capacity to think that hierarical at all. Capital colonised not only land and atmosphere, but the cognitive frameworks through which we might have resisted.

ELAN

That risks becoming despair dressed in theoretical sophistication. The automation dividend — all this value the machines now generate — goes to perhaps eleven thousand individuals across the Western world. That is a political fact. It can be contested.

MIRA

And yet every serious attempt to legislate against technofeudal accumulation has failed — not because the ideas were wrong, but because the political substrate had already been hollowed out. The barbarism is precisely the gap between the forms of civilisation we maintain and the substance we have abandoned.

*Promted by Claude AI as an ironic test of overlapping interest that is meant to showcase the themes that could be debated in future. It is amusingly non-sensical, playing with the fact that the AI (LLM) knows all the right words but not in which order to place them, could be read as similiar to how a first listen might feel for a newcomer to this topic of debate. Prompt: "A fictional debate between two future disciples — one following Žižek, one following Varoufakis — set in a debate hall inside Hötorgsskrapan 2 in Stockholm, in a post-work future where white-collar labour has been automated by AI. The conversation was to focus on the theme of humanity's return to barbarism, specifically through the lens of having abandoned the planet as the foundational priority of civilisation. The spatial setting was to serve as backdrop only, with the intellectual content ranging across Western society broadly."



Img. 21: Chomsky & Foucault debate on human nature, 1971. Courtesy of Eindhoven University archive, photographer unknown.



Img. 22: Part of the stage of the debate hall on floor 16 of Hötorgsskrapan 2, 2075. Photograph by author.



Img. 23: Parts of the three upper most floors of Hötorgsskrapan, 2075. The debate hall and its corresponding gallery. Photograph by author.

The debate hall is made up of primarily the existing buildings resources and structure adapted to a new setting – utilising its intended infrastructural capabilities. The major design decision was made to cut open the concrete slabs between the three levels which were then used to create the gallery stand and stage. The only things added that do not exist there today is the railing and the three added beams in the ceiling compensating the removed pillars.

Reflection

The interrogation of this building is but one example of how to tackle a system or built environment, there are enormously different options that one could use but I felt that this best helped me exemplify the degree of cultural shift that we have to embrace through a neat enough method. This particular system which is very distinctly modernist and non-determinist is of course more easily digested and more direct in its intentions which might make it an easier task than others.

Hötorgsskraporna as a concept is so heavily impactful in reading the greater narrative of our built environment and societal development if digested and interrogated properly. The thesis work is a long exploration of placing these architectural entities through varying perspectives and context whether they be historical, political, material, cultural, or philosophical – throughout time. In doing so there are an infinite amount of entry points and creates a long and arduous process which reflects my ideals rather than a more objective perspective which is what the thesis set out to do.

The design is metaphorical and speculative to its core, putting server halls in these culturally significant buildings is a big stretch and hard to argue for, but the socioeconomic situation of our current trajectory makes it a probable outcome. But in doing this it is intended to understand how the balancing of variables and the sociopolitical undercurrents affect the architecture and spatial design of such impressionable modern buildings. Bringing this from a time where the undercurrents shaped the buildings into what it became, and then seeing the water change direction, leaving smaller traces and making the buildings stand on their own. This is the power of speculation beyond the prediction or proposal, there is a playful nature that can push imaginative boundaries.

If Tabula Rasa was about dismantling the existing in favor of a placeless infrastructure, the true progression of modernity – where sustainability as a main motive and working with the existing as it's the tagline – is why tabula rasa will eventually surrender, spatially. But in this case it only disappears for humanity. The concept of tabula rasa lives on in two manors. As the existential and philosophical distinction with the barbarian in mind, and for the infrastructural scale that goes beyond the spatial field, the cybernetics needs to fully surround it and grasp onto it. Why man leaves it behind is because man has to accept the harshness of discomfort of a posthistoric sustainability that can never on the same plane ignore or discard the existing as the early modernist ideology intended. Tabula rasa has its own plastic nature and so in its spatial death it is reborn ideologically and digitally.

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Img. 11: Gillblad, A. (2026). *Perspective of 3d point cloud of the two floors 5 & 6 from Hötorget building #2* [3d-point cloud render].

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